elements in play. Take the socio-economic reality. The progeny born to a robust, prosperous post-liberalisation middle class has entered the job market—and they own a set of life markers vastly different from their parents. The basics of sustenance are already met, so livelihood is not at stake, says Mishra. They are sheltered enough to be able to leave their windows open—sometimes even the door. Purpose, meaning, a more rounded self-growth, these are active ambitions.

Social media platforms are a vector unto themselves. "Earlier, we didn't hear the chatter. But the current generation doesn't hold back. They speak their mind. They are aware of mental health and know what they want in life. Organisations that don't exactly practise the values they espouse end up with a large number of disgruntled employees," says Gallup's Singh.

In fact, it's becoming common for workers to actually quit their jobs without having another in hand, says Mishra. Taking a gap year to pursue interests, travel or simply figure things out was once reserved for freak outliers. Now the idea is commonplace. Global human capital firm Aon's research on employee exits uncovered another nugget. Ranked in the top three reasons cited by workers now, right after issues with compensation and growth opportunity, are 'personal reasons': relations with the boss, working hours, even office commute. This was never the case in the past 10 years, says Roopank Chaudhary, partner, Aon India. Data captured by Aon over the first seven months of 2026 contains a related surprise. Attrition, falling to the pre-COVID range of 16.2 per cent by 2025, has ticked back up to 18 per cent already. But within that, layoffs are up only from 3.4 to 4 per cent—the post-AI churn. Voluntary attrition is up from 12.8 to 14 per cent. That's partly a reflection of talent moving on to other jobs in a competitive market, yes, but also the mental churn. Those not quitting are hanging on even if they don't like the job.

It's no comfortable niche, though. It's wracked by doubt and depression. Almost 27 per cent of all the work-related calls they receive are about demotivation and disengagement, says Karuna Baskar, managing director of counselling firm ResilienceWorks. Gen Z is more concerned about work-life balance, she says, whereas mid- and senior-level employees, with more at stake, are concerned about layoffs and promotions. But the kind of office matters to both.

A Chief Human Resources Officer of a top manufacturing firm, on condition of anonymity, corroborates the effect from within. He admits organisations have failed to adjust culturally to the demographic shift, failing to offer younger professionals the value proposition they aspire to. An anonymous survey the firm conducted using Employee Net Promoter Score, which measures how likely employees are to recommend their workplace to others, was revelatory: total score 50, only 43 for the young. "They join a firm with certain expectations. They need a variety of experience, more exposure, they speak up more and want to be heard more. So, the role of leaders becomes extremely crucial: they have to engage with this cohort."

FROM FOREMANSHIP TO LEADERSHIP

Managerial disengagement, then, becomes a double whammy. Says Prabir Jha, former CHRO, Cipla, "Mediocrity in leadership is very stark today. People with technical skills are promoted as people leaders." They bring either a foreman mentality or an algorithmic style; empathy is not in their skillset. So, the young are unable to repose faith in managers, managers are themselves edgy about their job—the company completes the vicious triangle. "They've been using layoffs as a silver bullet for blips in business, so people don't believe anything they say," Jha adds. So, a low-trust culture comes to pervade the air. Baskar suggests everyone is susceptible to feeling uncredited, or perceiving a lack of appreciation or fairness. The result is that grey zone of quiet quitting—where, at a stretch, "competent work is still possible, but excellent work is unlikely". A shamiana where imperatives are negotiated and married: space and meaning for the self, and a toehold on a fast-spinning world.

The trend is not sector-specific, but one clue is how job-seeking has ratcheted up in the fraught landscape of IT. Staffing firm Xpheno says 26 per cent—over 465,000 of the 1.79 million employees at the top 16 listed Indian IT services firms—are actively looking this year. Nearly 4.2 times higher than last year. "Entry- to junior-level talent, especially, is seeking safer alternatives before their roles are made redundant," says Xpheno CEO Francis Padamadan. And the paradox of quiet quitting amidst job uncertainty? Winning the H-1B lottery was aspirational for this cohort, says Padamadan. Chances dropping to nearly one-fourth means their dream has died on them. Work in maintenance mode is that despair getting articulated.

What must be done when the foremost question for workers, as Singh says, is: "Why should I work?" Organisations could start by recognising that this is not laziness. Baskar calls for a higher tolerance of boundary-setting—she calls it normal self-preservation, not disengagement. "In fact, breaks help workers return refreshed, capable of more productive work," she says. Neog calls for a human touch: a personal note, verbal validation, an email. But the crisis also calls for something deeper. Deloitte's 2025 Gen Z and Millennial Survey found that 'purpose' is what animates them and creates well-being. Organisations, most of all, need to cognise this shift where workers are no longer willing to sell their souls for a salary. ■

WHAT THE BOSSES THINK

42%

CITE WEAK ORGANISATIONAL CULTURE AND MISALIGNMENT OF VALUES AS THE KEY REASON BEHIND RISE OF QUIET QUITTING IN INDIA**

*** Source: Gallup and Institute of Directors (India) 2026 report 'Rebuilding Indian Workplaces for the Future', based on an online survey of 181 IoD members, including board members and senior business and governance leaders*